There was a method to this mayhem, but one needed years of experience to know it. Still, even if one were to find a book on one's own, without Mr Shanbhag one could not easily take it off the shelf; else, dozens of other books would come tumbling down with it. There were frequent traffic jams as one went around the hump in the middle. This happened when visitors ignored the shop's unspoken rule, which was that walks of discovery be undertaken clockwise only.

The crowd of customers and the cramped quarters were, however, redeemed by the character of the man in charge. Once, I went to buy some books for a friend in America who wanted to acquaint himself, long distance, with modern India. I ordered Sunil Khilnani's *The Idea of India* and a volume of *Subaltern Studies*. Assessing the train of my thought, Mr Shanbhag then pulled out a breezy book on India by a not unknown Indian. 'Not that,' I said, 'I am looking for serious stuff.' 'Wait a minute,' said Mr Shanbhag, 'we don't want any more fights in *The Hindu*.' Titters of laughter broke out from the men and women in the shop who had caught the put-down, which referred to a bloody polemic which I had then just started in the pages of that newspaper. Now, it was *my* turn to turn crimson at Premier's.

III

In January 2001, my wife and I threw a party to celebrate thirty years in the life of Bangalore's best-loved bookshop (and bookseller). She had printed a card with a photo of the shop's inner circle, looking even madder than we had imagined it. Those who were invited all intimated that they would attend, but I was very nervous that the chief guest would not show up. The party was scheduled for a Sunday, on which day Mr Shanbhag usually kept his shop open in the mornings. I was there at 9.30, chewing my nails until he arrived. He came at 10, and for the next two hours I hovered around him. At noon he gave in, closed his shop, and drove his car behind mine to our home.